day and let us discuss how to save face', Mukherjee recalls telling his perplexed team.

The teams met on Sunday at 9 a.m. at the guest house in Jamshedpur. Officials with bleary eyes, fatigue and anxiety writ large on their faces, were ready with sheaves of papers containing their ideas. This was perhaps the first Sunday that they had been summoned to work.

After throwing down the gauntlet, Ratan worked the phone virtually every day with Irani, demanding updates on the progress of the new plans they were implementing. It kept the teams on their toes. And, within a month, Ratan was back in Jamshedpur to personally assess the progress. He met the anxious team and senior functionaries in the boardroom. There was no mistaking his focus. Mukherjee recalls him saying, 'Benchmark performance parameters with the best in the world. If they can achieve, we can achieve. Copy whatever we can. Innovate what cannot be copied.'

'We did not know how to achieve; all we knew was that we [had] to achieve,' and it exasperated the team, says Mukherjee. Ratan never took no for an answer. He would not be satisfied with incremental progress. To achieve growth and quality, he set a high goal and began benchmarking the company 'not against SAIL or other domestic producers but POSCO'.

Ratan returned in January of the next year to review the progress again. This time he sat with the team to work out the maths to cut costs. The operational team made an impressive presentation outlining how, for the first time in the company's history, there would not only be no rise in cost of production, which averaged around 5 per cent per annum, but the cost would in fact be reduced by Rs 350 per tonne by March 1994. But the chairman refused to accept any reduction in the target, of dropping costs by Rs 500 per tonne, that he had been assured in Mumbai would be achieved before March 1994.

Ratan also made frequent visits to Jamshedpur and Calcutta, reviewing and discussing the progress TISCO was making. He was persistent and relentless in demanding change. He instilled in the workforce the 'will to work, the will to win' and the 'aspiration to grow and the aspiration to be a world leader', effecting a change in their 'DNA', adds Koushik Chatterjee, group executive director and chief financial officer (CFO) of Tata Steel at the time. Ratan made them do the 'unthinkable', he says. He adds that Ratan gave the key leaders targets and was able to 'emotionally charge' them, 'tease out innovative ideas' and break 'the cage of inhibition' and